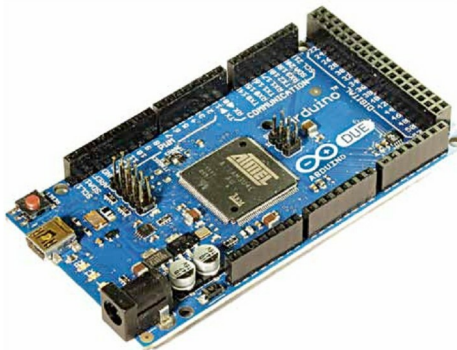


ARDUINO: THE NUMERO UNO PROTOTYPING PLATFORM

In less than a decade since its inception, Arduino has evolved as a phenomenon in the electronics space—across the globe as well as in India. Here are the key reasons that have paved the way for shaping up of an eco-system around Arduino, comprising a huge community of electronics designers, engineering students, hobbyists and hardware vendors



■ VANDANA SHARMA

Arduino needs no introduction. Ever since its genesis in 2005, this Open Source electronics prototyping platform has gained immense popularity amidst artists, designers, hobbyists, and anyone interested in creating interactive objects or environments. Started as a small project aimed at developing a device for controlling student-built interactive design projects, Arduino has turned into an electronics hardware move-

ment of its kind. More than 120,000 Arduino boards had been shipped as of February 2010 alone. In less than a decade, its popularity has broken all bounds. So much so that even powerful prototyping platforms such as BeagleBoard are seen catching up with Arduino.

What makes Arduino a 'hit' amongst design engineers, hobbyists, students and novices in the field of electronics? To find out, we probed a few design engineers and companies that provide Arduino boards, projects

and shields in India. Here are a few points that emerged from this discussion.

1 A simple platform that offers ease of use

"Arduino is an extremely easy-to-use platform compared to many other proprietary boards. Arduino users are not electronics geeks, they are artists, teachers, school students—you just have to name it. As against other boards, Arduino does not teach you the 'what' but the 'how' of electronics. No other board currently offers the flexibility of use on multiple operating systems, great library software, community support and super drivers," says Saptarshi Chatterjee, head-strategic alliance, Robosoft Systems.

"India has a large number of engineering graduates who are probably not design engineers but into different job roles like business or finance. They form a critical mass apart from students who use Arduino to design useful and fun projects without spending years in learning basic electronics. Hence, given the fact that it is a simple platform, Arduino is a great training platform to create better design engineers in India," adds Chatterjee.

Ajay Jadhao, founder and owner, Revosys, and partner, Analogue Technologies, seconds the thought: "The most important thing in designing is knowing what you want to do.